including a return to the fundamentals of US interests and strategy that held since the nineteenth century. Old and outdated assumptions about the geopolitical direction of the Indo-Pacific were discarded, and Washington was forced to reformulate American strategy, even as its overarching goals remained the same. The objectives of US strategy in the Indo-Pacific in the twenty-first century remain constant—namely, maintaining peace and stability, promoting democracy, and developing trade relations. These ambitious goals are becoming more difficult to achieve given the many problems noted above, as well as others that afflict Asian nations, including democratic backtracking, demographic pressures, corruption, political paralysis, environmental devastation, and the like.[41]

In particular, China's determination to dominate the skies and waters of the Indo-Pacific raises the question of the shape of future US strategy in the Indo-Pacific. Rising tensions in Asia, whether over disputed borders, historical issues, or rogue nations like North Korea, also draw the United States closer to the region. America's five formal treaty alliances and close relations with other nations remain the bedrock of its presence in the Indo-Pacific. These relations have endured because Washington has been willing to promise to spend American lives and treasure on the defense of its allies and to provide public goods such as protection of vital waterways.

The US security presence in Asia begins with the US Indo-Pacific Command (USINDOPACOM), headquartered on Oahu in Hawaii and composed of nearly 330,000 service members and civilian employees. The US Pacific Fleet comprises roughly 130,000 sailors and civilians; 200 ships, including five carrier strike groups; and 1,100 aircraft. Pacific Air Forces fields over 420 aircraft, including advanced F-22 fighters; while US Army Pacific has 106,000 personnel; and US Marine Corps Forces, Pacific, deploys 86,000 Marines and 640 aircraft.[42] Forward based throughout the region, particularly in Japan, Guam, and South Korea, these forces maintain a constant presence to defend US interests, allies, and regional stability. Added to this is US diplomatic